

Introduction

The move towards online shopping or e-commerce is an inevitable one. Though not a new concept, e-commerce has moved from the once-burnt hands of the early adopters to the masses. As more and more people around the world (but more specifically, in our country) get connected – through not just PCs, but even mobiles – we will see a rise in the number of transactions online. Perhaps not just the number of things being sold, but also the types of things and *how* they are sold. So what has changed over the years? Is it just more people online equals more e-commerce? Or has there been a shift in the mindset?

To answer these questions let's look at the way things were bought traditionally. In the real world (physical shopping) there was an element of touch and feel – something which we took for granted. There was also the notion of accountability. Should something go wrong with the product you purchased, the seller was always nearby. You could get him to change it, you could crib, rant, vent and maybe even get your money back. Lastly, there were those little pieces of paper you still carry around in your wallet. Cash.

For this rise in e-commerce we are witnessing today, things had to evolve. The web sites themselves had to try to incorporate or at least emulate as many of these real world experiences as possible, and at the same time the consumer had to change his mindset and come up with his own workarounds. To get over the lack of touch and feel, e-commerce web sites started showing product pictures differently. They developed zoom and 360 degree views. This was accompanied by reviews. Testimonials came about to build trust. Money back guarantees became the norm and product replacements / exchanges were offered. The consumer on the other hand began evolving his own methods. For touch and feel the physical shops or friend's purchases were always there. For actual purchase online turned out cheaper! How? The seller had lesser overheads. The consumer's trust in online shopping was further bolstered when he heard stories of friends and family doing successful transactions online. "Hey my money actually reached the seller in a digital form and no one stole it as it made its way through the internet in the form of bits and bytes", was a revelation many a